



IF THE QIN SHOULD EVER GET HIS WAY WITH THE WORLD, THEN THE WHOLE WORLD WILL END UP HIS PRISONER

THE FIRST EMPEROR UNIFIES CHINA (221 BCE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Han China

BEFORE

1600–1046 BCE Shang dynasty rules.

c. 1046–771 BCE Western Zhou dynasty.

771–476 BCE Spring and Autumn Period (the first half of the Eastern Zhou dynasty).

551–479 BCE Life of Kong Fuzi (known as Confucius).

476–221 BCE Warring States Period (the second half of the Eastern Zhou dynasty).

AFTER

140–87 BCE Reign of Han Emperor Wudi (Liu Che)—a time of imperial expansion.

220–581 CE Three Kingdoms and Six Dynasties Period.

581–618 Sui dynasty.

618–907 Tang dynasty.

in culture, ethnicity, and language. During the era known to Chinese historians as the Spring and Autumn Period (771–476 BCE), the region was nominally under the control of Zhou dynasty kings, but in reality their feudal system of government meant that only a token authority rested with the royal throne, while feudal lords held genuine power over what were effectively autonomous states. Up to 140 small states competed for power and territory.

The Spring and Autumn Period gave way to the Warring States Period (476–221 BCE), in which power was consolidated into the hands of seven kingdoms: Qi, Chu, Yan, Han, Zhao, Wei, and Qin. At this point in China's history it was by no means certain that an over-arching Chinese identity or state would emerge. If anything, it was more likely that the considerable geographical, climatic, cultural, and ethnic differences between the various kingdoms would see the region develop in a similar fashion to Europe many centuries later, with multiple distinct and divergent national entities.

The rise of Qin

In 247 BCE, a 13-year-old prince named Ying Zheng succeeded to the throne of Qin. He inherited a militarized state, in which effective bureaucracy, powerful armies, and competent generals combined to produce a formidable and ruthless war machine. Zheng had rivals executed or exiled, appointed very effective generals and counselors, and conquered the six

China is probably the most enduring coherent state in world history, and to an extraordinary extent this is due to the will of one man: Qin Shi Huang, the self-styled First Emperor. Before he unified ancient China in 221 BCE, it was a region of diverse states, differing